



Into the jungle

Church-Centric Bible Translation in South America

South America is home to over 900 people groups. Many of them are unreached by the gospel, living in dense jungles and involved in uneasy relationships with the outside world. In these challenging circumstances, Bible translation is catalyzing the growth of the church.

The Yuracani live in a sensitive South American country. Their numbers are small—less than 10,000. They do not have a translation of the Bible in their



LANGUAGE OVERVIEW

Region:	South America
People group:	Yuracani + Quipa*
Language:	Yuracani + Quipa*
Native speakers:	< 25,000
Status:	Partially Reached**

*name changed for security

**status from Joshua Project



TRANSLATION OVERVIEW

People involved:	30+
Time active:	July 2020 - present
Current goal:	Full Bible
Outside funding:	\$0

indigenous language, though some of them profess Christianity. The government makes it difficult for Westerners to interact with the indigenous communities. When a people group is in deep spiritual need—and yet so small and sealed off from the outside world—what can be done to help them?

The Yuracani recognized their needs and resolved to do something about it. They contacted a local organization that aims to equip the Latin American church for Bible translation. The Yuracani were excited to work with a paradigm that placed the church's needs at the center of the translation work.

Church-Based Bible Translation encompasses a wide range of Bible translation paradigms. When the church is well-established, it can pursue Bible translation with little outside assistance. This is known as *Church-Produced* Bible Translation. When the church is young and not yet theologically grounded, translation work takes place with the help of local and outside organizations as an integral part of the young church's discipleship. This is known as *Church-Centric* Bible Translation. Most of the efforts in South America,



including the Yuracani's, qualify as *Church-Centric* Bible Translation.

To cultivate theological formation and discipleship, the local organization helped the Yuracani translate unfoldingWord® Open Bible Stories (OBS)—a collection of 50 key biblical stories designed for translation training, evangelism, and discipleship. Translation work began in July 2020. The local organization visited the Yuracani multiple times to check the progress of the translation. It was available in both print and audio formats by October 2022. Supplementing this resource, the team translated a list



of inductive questions for each of the 50 stories, enabling their people to understand the implications of each one.

The team also drafted the book of Titus, and they're now working on 3 John. Some of the Yuracani are working on translation, and the broader language community, too, has supplied critical feedback throughout the process. The translation of Open Bible Stories is already making an impact, with Yuracani gathering in groups to read and discuss it. "The Yuracani are one of 3,600 ethnic groups that still do not have the Bible in their language," says one of the project leaders, "but God's love for them does not diminish. We know that no effort is too much to make the gospel of salvation known to them."

Translation for the Quipa

Another people group in South America, the Quipa, are beginning Bible translation. The Quipa had completed Open Bible Stories in February 2022, but they were hungry for more. Their story highlights the amazing ways in which people groups around the world are generating the resources necessary to sustain Bible translation. Local churches often struggle to get the resources they need to translate the Bible. Sometimes they need financial support, but often their needs are much broader than that. Many times, they need churches to generously donate time and personnel.



How can church leaders create a culture of generosity in their people group?

The Quipa have been doing this through an initiative called Stations of Generosity, or SOG. At SOG training events, leaders of local churches learn to develop a culture of generosity with a view toward sustaining long term ministry. The idea is inspired by the "Bible Women" of Mizoram, India, who, beginning in 1910, donated a handful of rice from each meal they prepared to the local church for it to sell and fund its work. Now, the churches of Mizoram are thriving, sustaining themselves with no support from the West. Many things become possible when everyone contributes a little, whether of their finances, time, or talents.

Stations of Generosity fuels Church-Centric Bible Translation by encouraging the church to take the lead not only in carrying out the translation work, but also in gathering the resources to sustain it. A fully equipped, self-sustaining church is a force for gospel-driven change. This is becoming a reality for the Quipa.



Upon receiving SOG training alongside other church networks in South America, the Quipa were so excited by the prospects that they translated the SOG training material for use in their churches, including one composed entirely of indigenous Quipa believers. They've seen immense success among the local churches, setting them up to continue translating the entire Bible into their language. Their goal isn't to raise funds: rather, they want to rally the church behind the translation work and encourage people to joyfully invest their time in whatever way they can.

Looking ahead

Church-Centric Bible Translation is growing among the indigenous churches of South America as more and more of them look for solutions to their Bible

translation needs. Though many of them are not yet established enough to take the lead in the translation efforts, they are nonetheless playing a vital role, working alongside local organizations with a view toward building capacity for long-term translation ability. Through initiatives like Stations of Generosity and the ripe mission fields of tribes like the Yuracani and the Quipa, the future is bright for Bible translation in South America.

“As we consider these things, we think about how God has positioned all of us at this place and time,” said a Quipa translation leader. “He has been preparing us all our lives for this translation work.”

